BUILDER, STEP 14

CLAUDE.md, the house rules for one folder.

One short file. Read at the start of every session.

What goes in, what stays out, and our test: the same question without and with house rules.

CLAUDE.MD FROM DAY ONE

An issue goes in. Our own AI agents, customized per job, plan, build, test, review and open a pull request.

	TYPICAL START OF ONE STEP
Before	162,168 tokens, before any work
Other repos	21 to 55 thousand, same workflows
Now	57,581 tokens. About a third

The cause: every session loaded all instruction files. 35 rules now load only when they are needed, and a test fails if they grow back.

House rules are not a file you write once. Keep them short, keep checking.

WHAT GOES IN

15 lines. Rules you can check.

```
# House rules for this folder

## What this folder is
A weekly shipments export from our transport
planning. The data is made up.

## Rules
- A week is an ISO week, Monday to Friday.
- BE-NL and NL-BE are two separate routes.
- Every number comes from the file.
- For the Monday overview, follow monday-overview.md.

## Never
- Never change or delete shipments-export-sample.csv.
- Never create a file unless I ask for one.
- Never send anything.
```

Shortened for the slide. The full file is in the kit.

OUR TEST

"Give me the Monday overview of this export."

	WITHOUT	WITH CLAUDE.MD
Words	545 and 507	149 and 111
Seconds	65 and 87	25 and 25
Answer	Two different reports, with client tables and advice	The route table we meant, both times
Numbers	Right	Right

Same made-up export, two runs each. No run changed the file.

BUT

It ignored one rule. Twice.

The rule: "Start with a table." What came first:

```
Run 1: Both weeks in the file are complete
       (Monday to Friday). ...

Run 2: ## Overview: ISO week 42 (12-16 Oct 2026)
       against week 41 (5-9 Oct 2026)
```

Anthropic: Claude treats CLAUDE.md as "context, not enforced configuration".

House rules guide. They do not lock.

THE FIX

A rule anyone can check, in a file for one job.

```
# monday-overview.md
1. Your first line is the table.
   No title or sentence before it.
```

```
| Route | Last week | This week | Change |
| BE-BE | 25        | 60        | +35    |
| NL-BE | 77        | 101       | +24    |
| BE-FR | 71        | 48        | -23    |
| BE-NL | 47        | 42        | -5     |
```

Column titles shortened for the slide.

One run: table first, biggest change first, then 3 lines.
One run is not proof.

GOOD TO KNOW

Short wins.

→ /init wrote us 26 lines that described the columns well. None of our rules. Keep two lines, add your own

→ Under 200 lines, Anthropic says. A 2026 study: context files raised cost by over 20% on average, and repository overviews in them did not help

→ Folders above load too. Our first test went wrong because of that

→ Never put passwords or client data in it

FREE FILES

Your folder, your rules.

→ A 15-line CLAUDE.md template

→ The Monday context pack, and a blank one

→ What not to put in CLAUDE.md

→ Our /init output, to compare

On my profile under Featured: AI Starter Kit, step 14.

Tomorrow: make Claude Code ask before it changes anything, and undo a step.